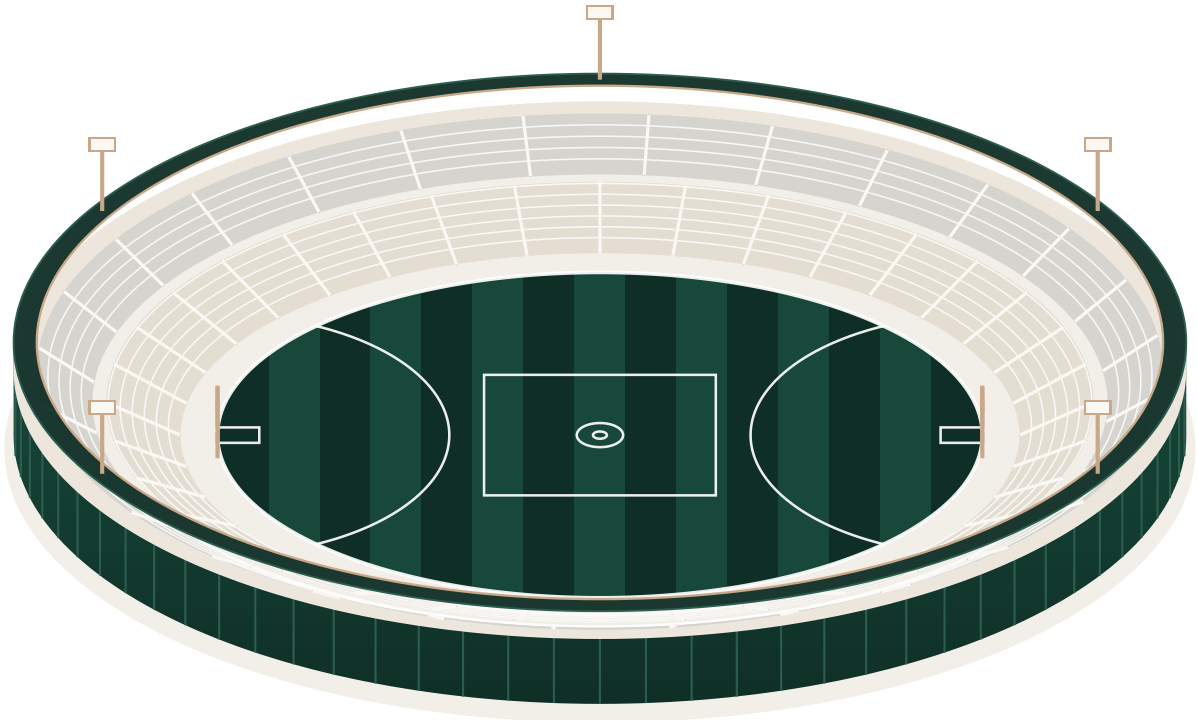
MARKET INTELLIGENCE BRIEFING / OCTOBER 2026

The AFL in 2026: Crowds, Club Finances, and Partner Deals

Crowds, money, and rights in Australia's most attended league.

7.77M home and away attendances in 2026, a VFL/AFL record according to the AFL



Prepared by Katherine Rowe
Playbook Strategies / playbookstrategies.co

Independent analysis. Not affiliated with or endorsed by the AFL or its clubs.

AUSTRALIAN FOOTBALL LEAGUE / LAST UPDATED OCTOBER 11, 2026 / PREPARED BY KATHERINE ROWE

The AFL in 2026: Crowds, Club Finances, and Partner Deals

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1 Executive summary

The commercial picture

The AFL drew a record 7.77 million to its home and away matches in 2026. Each ground turns those crowds into very different amounts of money. The commercial questions are where a bigger crowd could add revenue, how each fan is monetized, and which rights a partner might buy.

2026 HOME AND AWAY ATTENDANCE
7.77M
207 matches, a record according to the AFL

MODELED ATTENDANCE HEADROOM
2.3M
A benchmark scenario, with 74% at the MCG and Marvel

REPORTED MATCH REVENUE PER ATTENDEE
A$8.58–24.48
Five clubs, 2025; accounting and venue terms differ

1. **Venue size shapes the growth question.** Melbourne holds most of the modeled headroom, while Brisbane and Sydney have large supporter bases for the capacity they offer and already fill about 80% of their grounds. Average fill alone cannot show unmet demand, so sales and attendance by fixture are needed to see which matches reach capacity and which need new buyers. Sections 3–4

2. **A bigger crowd is one of several ways to earn more.** The five clubs that disclose match revenue earn between A$8.58 and A$24.48 per attendee, a spread of almost three times. Pricing, membership accounting, and venue agreements all feed that figure, so a growth target needs retained revenue alongside attendance. Sections 5–6

3. **Whoever controls an asset decides who can buy it.** The league, the clubs, the broadcasters, and the venues each sell their own rights. Six league agreements reach their published end year by the end of 2027, counting the Asahi portfolio once. Most public deal values come from press reports and estimates of different dates. Sections 7–10

How to read this briefing: crowds come from the 2026 men's home and away season, and club finances come from 2025. Scenarios and public page counts carry their own tags. All money is in Australian dollars unless marked US$.

Background: why the AFL

Australian football is a domestic code. Almost all professional play happens in one country, yet the AFL draws more attendances per resident than any of the 11 major leagues compared in this briefing. A closed national market with very frequent attendance makes the league an unusual commercial case.

1897
First VFL season, after 8 clubs left the Victorian Football Association

27.8
Home and away attendances per 100 Australians in 2026, the highest of 11 leagues

8 of 8
States and territories that hosted 2026 home and away matches, at 17 grounds

From a Melbourne competition to a national league

Members of the Melbourne Football Club wrote the first rules of the game in 1859. Eight clubs formed the Victorian Football League in 1896, and the VFL stayed a Melbourne competition for most of the next century. South Melbourne moved to Sydney in 1982, and West Coast and Brisbane joined in 1987. The VFL became the AFL in 1990, and Adelaide, Fremantle, and Port Adelaide joined over the next 7 years. Gold Coast joined in 2011, GWS in 2012, and Tasmania will enter as the 19th club in 2028.

Why the league is worth close study

- **Attendance frequency.** Australia has about 28 million residents, and the AFL recorded 27.8 home and away attendances per 100 of them in 2026. La Liga and the Premier League follow at 23.5 and 22.8. The NHL, NBA, NFL, and MLS each record 6.0 or fewer. The AFL reaches its rate with an average crowd of about 37,500, so the rate depends on fans who attend many times a season and on large grounds such as the MCG.
- **A national league with a Melbourne core.** Victoria has 10 of the 18 clubs, and 9 of them play at 2 main grounds and compete for the same households in Melbourne. Each of the other 4 mainland states has 2 clubs. In 2026 the league also took home and away matches to Tasmania, the ACT, and the Northern Territory, so its fixture reaches every state and territory.
- **Central control of the money.** The AFL sells the broadcast rights under its A$4.5B agreement with Seven, Foxtel, and Telstra, owns Marvel Stadium, and passes about a third of club revenue back to the clubs. The clubs sell their own memberships and partnerships.

2 Market snapshot and scope

Figures cover the 2026 home and away season and 2025 financial reporting unless noted.

HOME AND AWAY ATTENDANCE

7.77M

7,772,015 across 207 matches, a VFL/AFL record according to the AFL

INDUSTRY REVENUE, 2025

A$2.178B

AFL and 18 clubs, money passed between them counted once

AFL REVENUE, 2025

A$1.207B

Up A$164M, or 15.7%, on 2024

CLUB DISTRIBUTIONS, 2025

A$468M

From club reports; the AFL's own club support figure is A$461.5M

BROADCAST AGREEMENT

A$4.5B

Seven, Foxtel and Telstra, 2025 to 2031

CURRENT PARTNERS

35

Brands on the AFL directory; one value disclosed by the partner

Scope and dates

The attendance analysis covers all 207 men's home and away matches in 2026, with finals appearing only as Grand Final context in Section 9. Club finances and match revenue ratios use 2025 reports. The league partner census covers assets across the AFL, AFLW, and community programs. AFLW attendance and AFLW membership products sit outside this briefing, and a separate AFLW briefing will follow after the 2026 AFLW season ends in November.

How to read the evidence

Reported / calculated: published figures, or arithmetic on them. **Estimate / modeled:** survey ratios and illustrative scenarios. **Public page count:** what the analysis could find on public pages; contracts may hold more. Measures with different units appear separately. All money is in Australian dollars unless marked US$.

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1 Executive summary

Background: why the AFL

2 Market snapshot and scope

3 Attendance and venue capacity

4 Club audiences and home markets

5 Matchday revenue per attendee

6 Club finances and AFL distributions

7 Commercial inventory and renewal dates

8 League partner portfolio

9 Audience measures and broadcaster sponsors

10 Club memberships

11 State governments: Gather Round and Macquarie Point

12 Commercial priorities

13 Signals worth tracking

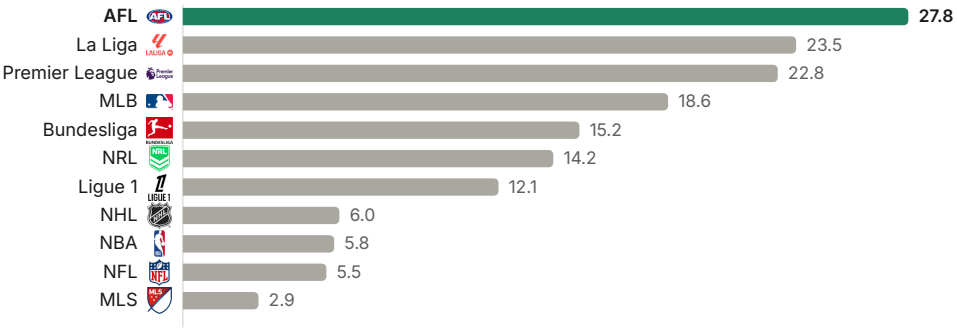
A–F Data, methods, sources and supporting charts

About the author

3 Attendance and venue capacity

The AFL recorded 27.8 attendances per 100 Australians in 2026, the highest rate of the 11 leagues compared here. The rate counts every visit, so a fan at 10 matches counts 10 times.

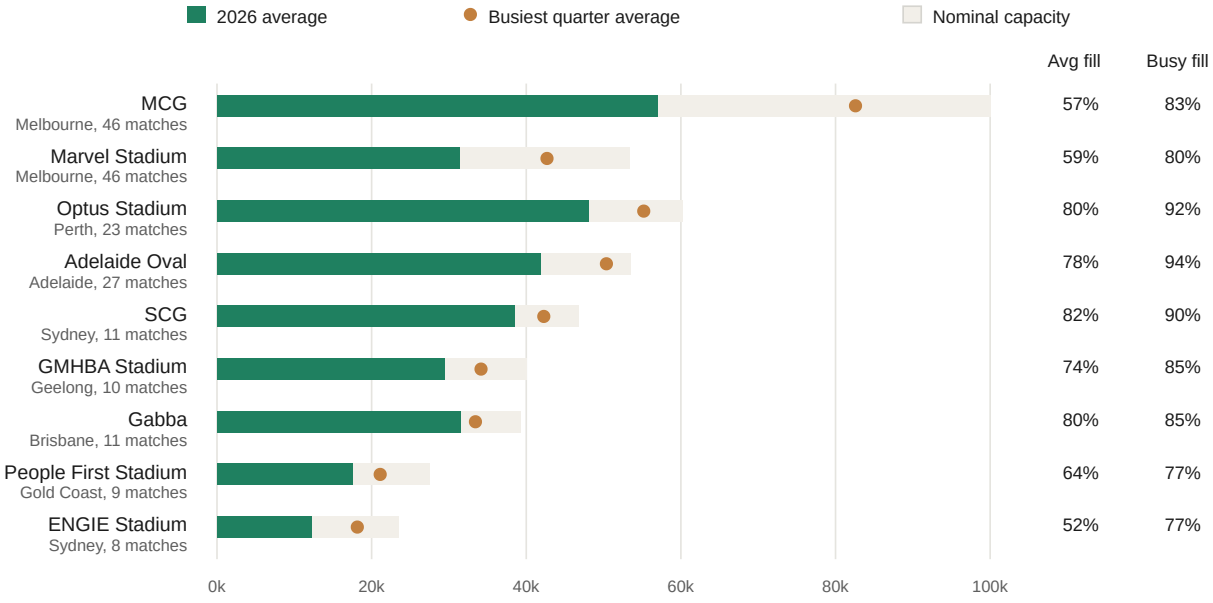
Figure 1. Attendance per 100 residents of the home market REPORTED / CALCULATED



The AFL leads on attendance per resident, which measures how often people across the market go to a match.

Source: Published league season attendance records; national statistical agency population estimates, middle of 2025. MLB, NHL, NBA and MLS use the United States and Canada; the NFL uses the United States alone.

Figure 2. Average crowd, biggest crowds and capacity at the nine main grounds REPORTED / CALCULATED



Measured in people, the MCG and Marvel show the widest gap between an average crowd and their busiest quarter of matches. Adelaide Oval, Optus Stadium, and the SCG reach 90% or more of capacity at their busiest, so one fill target cannot suit all nine grounds.

Source: afltables.com, 2026 home and away crowds; AFL.com.au, venue capacities. Biggest crowds are the average of each ground's busiest quarter of its 2026 home and away matches, using the full season at all nine grounds.

Measured against each main ground's average for its busiest quarter of matches, the league had about 2.3 million attendances of headroom in 2026, and 74% of it sat at the MCG and Marvel. All nine benchmarks use the full 2026 home and away season. Against nominal capacity, the gap would be about 4.1 million. Appendix D sets out the method.

4 Club audiences and home markets

Roy Morgan's supporter estimates and each club's home capacity measure different parts of a club's market. Across the league, there are 0.79 supporters for every place offered over the season. The ratio indicates the size of a market; ticket sales by fixture show demand.

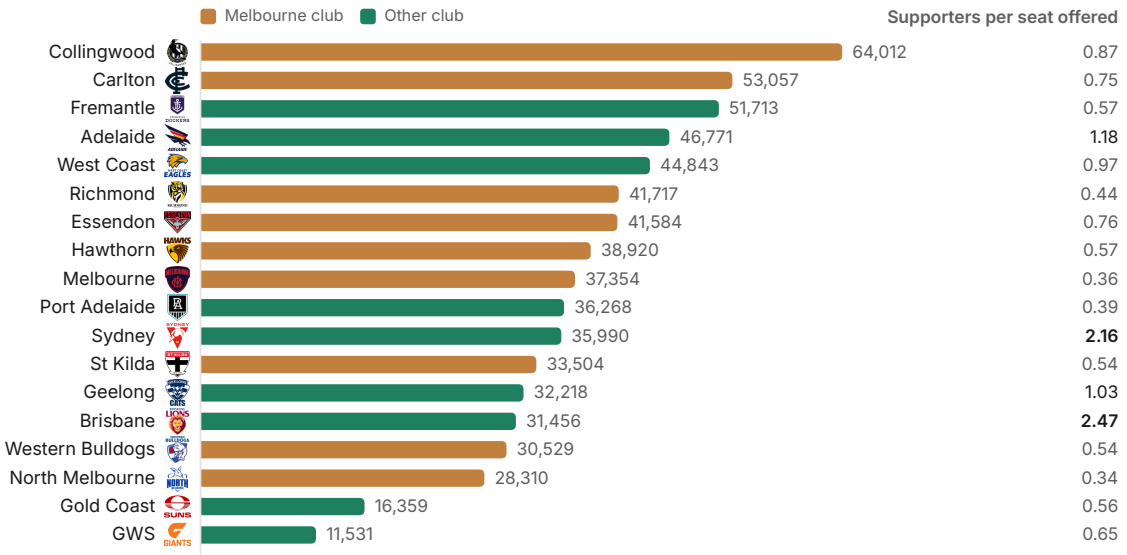
Figure 3. Home base of each club REPORTED / CALCULATED



Victoria has 10 of the 18 clubs. Nine of them sit within 38 kilometers of each other and play their home matches at the MCG and Marvel Stadium.

Source: AFL.com.au and club websites, club training and administrative bases.

Figure 4. Average home crowd and supporters per seat offered, 2026 ESTIMATE



Collingwood has the largest average home crowd at 64,012. Brisbane and Sydney have the most supporters for the capacity they offer, at 2.47 and 2.16 per place. Whether either market needs more seats depends on which fixtures sell out and how many of those supporters live within reach of the ground.

Source: afltables.com, 2026 home and away crowds; AFL.com.au, venue capacities; Roy Morgan, AFL supporter ladder, September 2026. Full club table in Appendix B.

4.1 Large supporter bases for the capacity

Brisbane and Sydney each have more than a million supporters in Roy Morgan's survey and fill about 80% of their grounds on average. Some of that support is national, from people who live too far away to attend often.

4.2 Large grounds and variable crowds

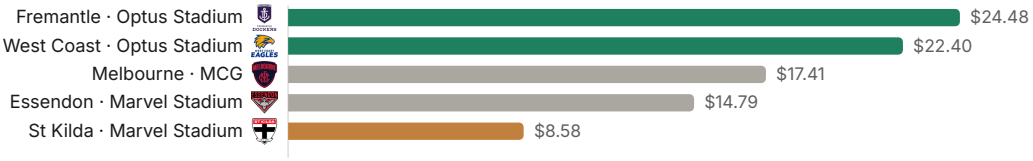
Richmond, Melbourne, Essendon, and Hawthorn each offered between about 785,000 and 1.02 million seats across their home matches. Their low ratios come partly from repeated access to large grounds, so opponents, timing, and venue terms belong in any review of their marketing.

Supporters and members: the gap between the 9.4 million supporters in Roy Morgan's survey and the 1.36 million published memberships is about 8.0 million. The two use different definitions and periods, and the AFL does not remove duplicates from its membership tallies.

5 Matchday revenue per attendee

Five clubs disclose match revenue separately from membership. Dividing their 2025 match revenue by home attendance gives between A$8.58 and A$24.48 per attendee. Each ratio uses the club's own revenue line, so the figures differ from average ticket prices.

Figure 5. Reported match revenue per attendee, 2025 CALCULATED



Source: Club 2025 annual reports for the five clubs that disclose gate revenue; afltables.com, 2025 home attendance.

DISCLOSED GATE REVENUE BY CLUB

CLUB	REVENUE LINE AS REPORTED	2025 REVENUE	HOME ATTENDANCE	PER HEAD
Fremantle	Match revenue	$12,323,412	503,341	$24.48
West Coast	Match revenue	$10,493,000	468,334	$22.40
Melbourne	Gate receipts	$7,833,621	449,984	$17.41
Essendon	Match receipt and stadium revenue	$6,511,030	440,377	$14.79
St Kilda	Match returns and secondary market	$3,067,104	357,314	$8.58

5.1 What drives the spread

The highest ratio is almost three times the lowest. Before reading the spread as a pricing gap, a club would need to know what each revenue line includes and how each venue agreement splits matchday income.

The revenue labels differ: Essendon's includes stadium revenue, and St Kilda's includes resale on the secondary market. Clubs book reserved seat memberships as membership revenue, while the attendance count includes member visits and every other kind of admission. Venue terms then decide how much income the club keeps. For all three reasons, the A$27 general admission price at the MCG and Marvel in 2025 does not compare directly with these ratios.

5.2 What A$1 or 10% more is worth

Adding A$1 per attendee shows the size of a matchday gain without assuming a club can match another venue's economics. With everything else held constant, 10% more revenue per attendee and 10% more attendance add the same amount.

ILLUSTRATIVE INCREASES USING 2025 ATTENDANCE AND REPORTED MATCH REVENUE

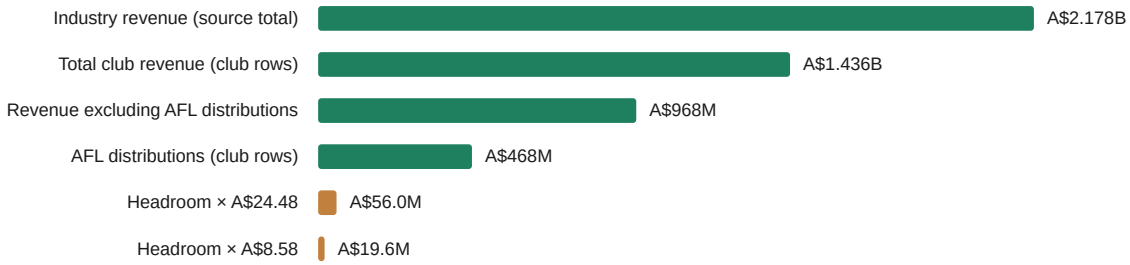
CLUB	HOME ATTENDANCE	A$1 MORE PER ATTENDEE	10% MORE PER ATTENDEE, OR 10% MORE ATTENDANCE
Fremantle	503,341	A$0.503M	A$1.232M
West Coast	468,334	A$0.468M	A$1.049M
Melbourne	449,984	A$0.450M	A$0.783M
Essendon	440,377	A$0.440M	A$0.651M
St Kilda	357,314	A$0.357M	A$0.307M

Extra attendance can add costs or draw income away from memberships, and a higher return per attendee may need a different product mix or venue agreement. Each club's own net figures would decide which option works.

5.3 What a club would need to know

- Net matchday revenue by fixture and admission type, showing membership allocations, paid tickets, concessions, and complimentary attendance.
- What the venue agreement returns to the club on tickets, food and beverage, signage and hospitality, and when it next falls due.
- How much of the membership base buys a reserved seat, since clubs book that revenue as membership and the gate line excludes it.

Figure 6. Club and league revenue alongside modeled attendance headroom MODELED



At the lowest and highest of the five ratios, the benchmark headroom is worth between A$19.6M and A$56.0M. The range mixes 2026 attendance scenarios with 2025 accounting ratios and counts revenue before the cost of serving a bigger crowd.

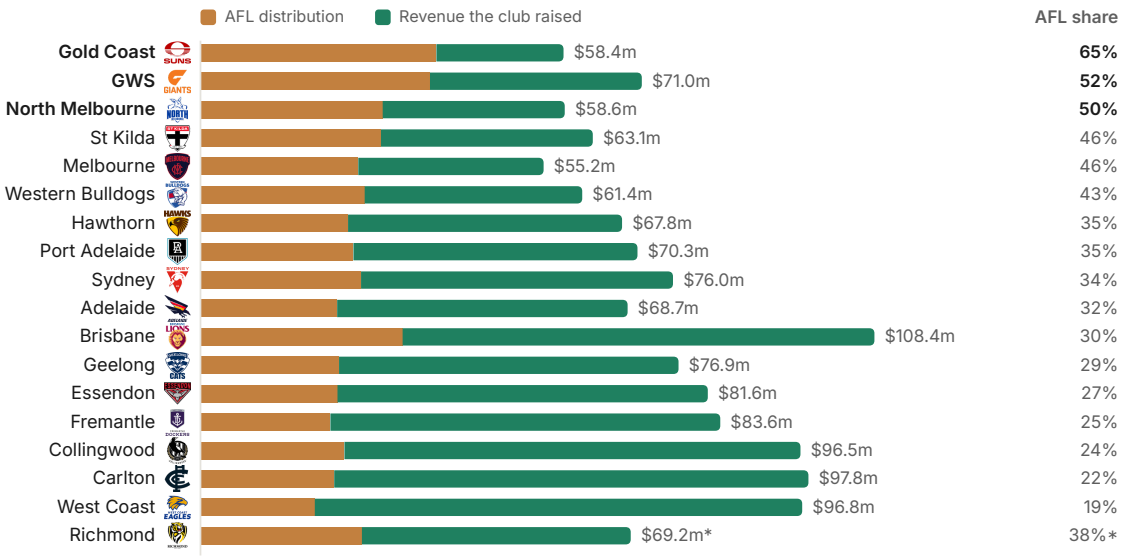
Source: afltables.com and AFL.com.au, 2026 crowds and capacities; club 2025 annual reports; SportsIndustryAU, 2025 club revenue.

6 Club finances and AFL distributions

AFL distributions are the money the league passes to its 18 clubs from central revenue, of which broadcast rights are the largest part. Club reports put the 2025 total at A$468M, about a third of club revenue. The AFL reports A$461.5M under its own club support measure, up from A$420.8M in 2024, and tied the rise to the new Collective Bargaining Agreement. The two totals measure different things.

The league weights distributions toward clubs that raise less on their own. The AFL share of club revenue runs from 19% at West Coast to 65% at Gold Coast. Gold Coast and GWS receive more than half their revenue from the AFL, which leaves them the most exposed to league funding decisions.

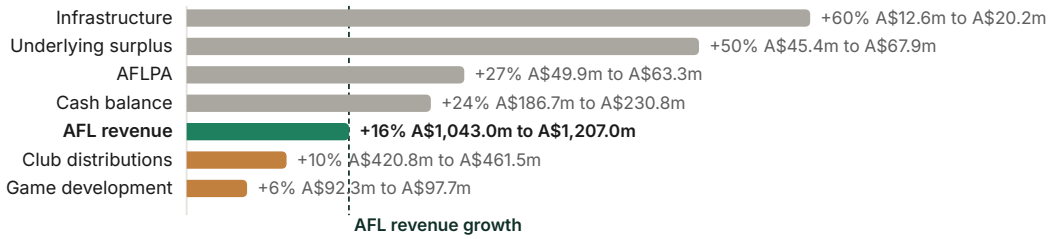
Figure 7. 2025 club revenue, split into AFL distribution and revenue the club raised REPORTED



Richmond's bar leaves out A$75M of Aligned Leisure revenue, and the asterisk marks the adjustment.

Source: AFL, 2025 financial result and 2025 Annual Report; SportsIndustryAU, 2025 club revenue. Distribution amounts come from each club's published share and sum to A$468M. *Richmond excludes A$75M of Aligned Leisure revenue; its share on reported revenue is 18%.

Figure 8. AFL financial measures, change from 2024 to 2025 REPORTED



AFL revenue grew 15.7% in 2025 and the league's club support measure grew 9.7%. The two rates do not show where the A$164M increase went, because expenditure, the surplus, and the cash balance each measure something different. The 2026 result will show whether the gap repeats.

Source: AFL, 2025 financial result (AFL.com.au). 2024 revenue calculated from the disclosed A$164M increase.

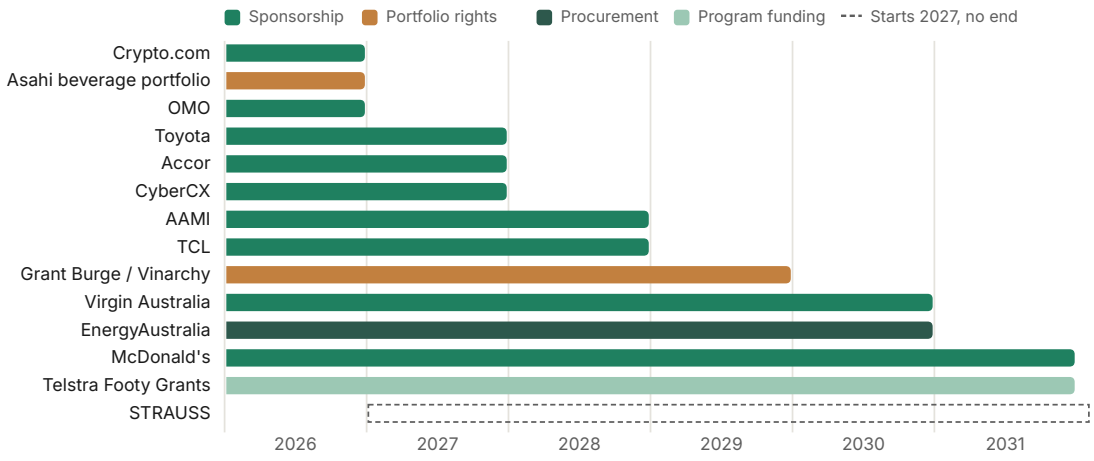
7 Commercial inventory and renewal dates

League, club, broadcaster, and venue agreements each give access to different assets. A sponsor's rights fee, its own activation budget, goods supplied in kind, and program funding are separate parts of a deal. Comparing deal values means knowing the seller, who controls the asset, and what the partner may use it for.

WHAT THE AFL SELLS AND WHO CONTROLS IT COMMERCIALLY (LEGAL TITLE CAN SIT ELSEWHERE)

ASSET CLASS	INVENTORY	CONTROLLED BY	EXAMPLE PARTNERS
Competition and naming	Premiership Season, AFLW, Origin, Community Series	AFL	Toyota, NAB, AAMI
Matchday and field	Center circle, goal squares, match ball, LED, the ARC	AFL, with venue limits	Coles, McDonald's, CyberCX
Media and digital	Broadcast, AFL app and web, Tipping, Fantasy	AFL; Seven, Foxtel and Kayo for their own inventory	Seven, Foxtel, Telstra; Crypto.com
Events and awards	Brownlow, Mark and Goal of the Year, Draft	AFL	Colgate, Virgin Australia, Continental
Venue and hospitality	Marvel Stadium, suites, pouring rights, travel	AFL at Marvel; venue operators elsewhere	TCL, Grant Burge, Accor
Licensing and retail	Master license, AFL Shop, official football	AFL, licensed to Fanatics	Fanatics, Sherrin, PUMA
Community and pathways	Auskick, Footy Grants, umpire pathway	AFL	Telstra, Bunnings, Chemist Warehouse
Club IP and membership	Club marks, memberships, member benefits	The 18 clubs	Club partners

Figure 9. AFL agreements by public end year PUBLIC PAGE COUNT



Six league agreements reach a published end year by the end of 2027: Crypto.com, OMO, and the Asahi portfolio in 2026, and Toyota, Accor, and CyberCX in 2027. The Asahi agreement covers four directory brands: Gatorade, Cool Ridge, Pepsi, and Solo. The end year signals a renewal, but the current partner may still keep the rights.

Source: AFL.com.au partner announcements and trade press, compiled in the Playbook Strategies partner census, September 2026.

8 League partner portfolio

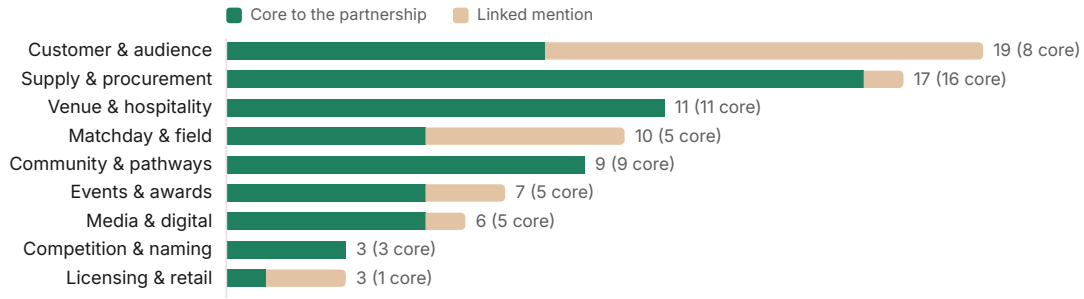
The AFL directory lists 35 brands. Hostplus is the only one whose sponsorship value is disclosed in filings. Press reports and estimates give figures for four more brands or portfolios, and some of those describe earlier contracts. Those figures differ in date, scope, and reliability.

Figure 10. The 35 current AFL corporate partners by tier PUBLIC PAGE COUNT

TIER	BRANDS	DIRECTORY BRANDS
Premier	1	Toyota
Major	10	AAMI, Carlton Draught, Coles, Continental Tyres, Crypto.com, McDonald's, NAB, Sportsbet, Telstra, Virgin Australia
Official	23	Accor Hotels, Bunnings Warehouse, BWS, Chemist Warehouse, Colgate, Cool Ridge, CyberCX, EnergyAustralia, Gatorade, Grant Burge, Hard Rated, Harvey Norman, Hostplus, Marsh, Monster Energy, OMO, Pepsi, Sharp EIT Solutions, Shell, Sherrin, Solo, TCL, Visit Victoria
Associate	1	PUMA

Source: AFL.com.au, corporate partners directory, 22 September 2026; Hostplus, FY2025 financial disclosures; trade press.

Figure 11. Partner links by asset class PUBLIC PAGE COUNT



Public announcements link partners most often to customer and audience assets (19 links) and to supply and procurement (17).

Source: AFL.com.au partners directory and partner announcements; trade press; Playbook Strategies classification of public evidence (Appendix A).

EVERY PUBLIC DEAL VALUE, BY LEVEL OF EVIDENCE

DEAL	WHAT IS PUBLIC	SOURCE	HOW TO USE IT
Seven, Foxtel and Telstra	A$4.5B, 2025 to 2031	League rights value	Media benchmark; total contract value across seven years
Hostplus	A$9.58M over five years	Hostplus FY2025 financial disclosures	Only value disclosed by a party to the deal
Toyota	A$74M over four years (2019 renewal)	Marketing Mag, 2019; prior contract	Attributed benchmark
Crypto.com	A$25M over five years from 2022	Crypto News Australia; AFL confirms the term	Attributed benchmark
Virgin Australia	Described as worth millions of dollars	Virgin Australia, February 2026	Scale band only
Sportsbet	Near A$100M over seven years	Affiliate Leaders, betting industry site; unconfirmed	Direction only
CUB and Asahi	About A$8M a year	Research and Markets estimate, 2025	Direction only
Fanatics	Master license, 2023 to 2032	Official, no value	Royalties, outside the sponsor count

Annual rights fees compare fairly only where contract scope and timing are known, and media rights, sponsorship estimates, licenses, and goods in kind do not add up to one portfolio value. Dividing A$4.5B by seven gives an average year of the media contract; the AFL does not disclose the annual figure. Categories with no visible league partner are leads for research, since unpublished exclusivity may still block them.

9 Audience measures and broadcaster sponsors

The AFL's own digital channels, broadcast totals, and the 18 club social followings each measure a different level of audience, as shown below.

Figure 12. Audience measures: units, period and interpretation DIFFERENT UNITS

CHANNEL	PERIOD	REPORTED SIZE	UNIT	INTERPRETATION
AFL broadcast	2026 season	370M	Aggregate audience contacts	Counts repeat viewing; one person counts many times
AFL social	Weekly	50M	Impressions	Counts each time content is shown
AFL app and web	Weekly	22.9M	Sessions	Counts visits; one person can make many
Foxtel Group	2025	15.1M	People reached	Reach as Foxtel reports it, for its own period
18 clubs, combined	2026 snapshot	14.9M	Social followers	Account totals across platforms; one person can follow several
AFL owned social	2026 snapshot	4.1M	Followers	Account totals; one person can follow several accounts
AFL app and web	Weekly	3.4M	Users	Users as the AFL defines them

Each measure suits a different asset and buyer, and the seven cannot be added together or ranked against each other.

Source: AFL.com.au, 2026 season launch and viewership releases; Foxtel Media, 2026 AFL release; SportsIndustryAU, club social 2026; independent trackers, September 2026.

GRAND FINAL ATTENDANCE
100,023
the MCG, 26 September

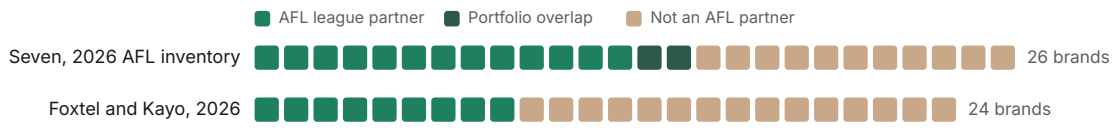
AVERAGE TV AUDIENCE
4.52M
Seven and 7plus

TOTAL REACH
6.5M
the year's top program

GRAND FINAL WEEK
350,000+
Footy Fest and the Parade

These figures cover one match and its week, outside the home and away analysis. The AFL reported 8,528,279 attendances for the season, 756,264 of them at finals. Footy Fest and the Parade add reach for the event and earn the clubs no gate revenue.

Figure 13. Brands buying AFL audience from a broadcaster PUBLIC PAGE COUNT



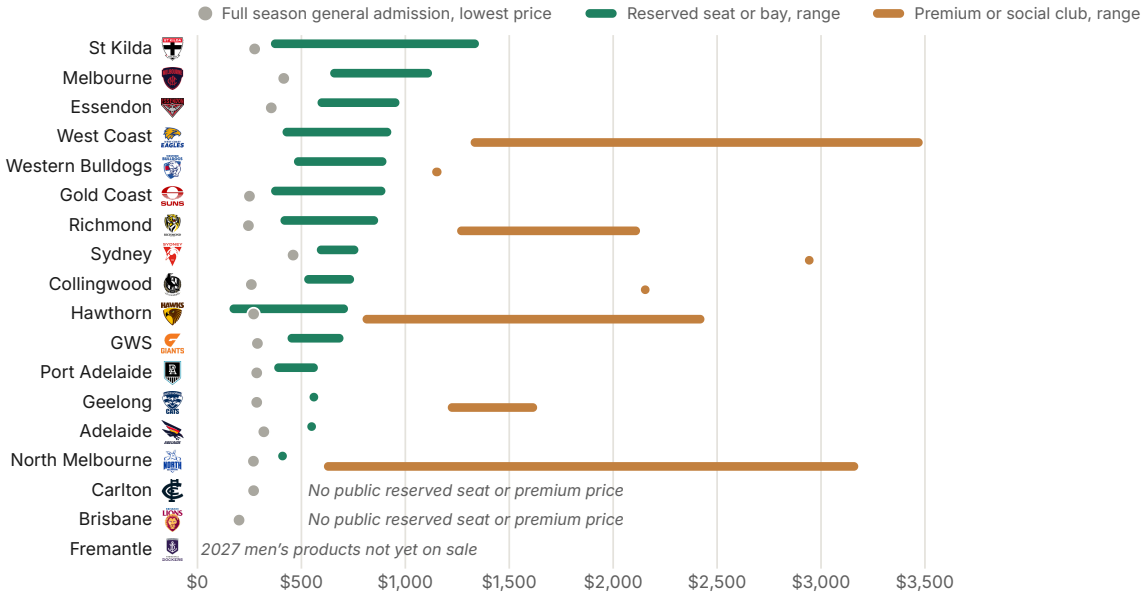
The census lists 26 brands with Seven and 24 with Foxtel and Kayo. Of those 50 broadcaster relationships, 26 belong to brands with no direct AFL partnership. A brand that buys from both broadcasters appears twice, so the number of separate advertisers may be lower. These brands are prospects for league rights.

Source: Mediaweek, Seven 2026 AFL sponsors; Foxtel Media, 2026 AFL sponsorship lineup; AFL.com.au, partners directory.

10 Club memberships

Each of the 18 clubs sells its own memberships and publishes them to its own standard, so the club figures here count what clubs chose to show on their websites.

Figure 14. Publicly listed adult membership prices by access type PUBLIC PAGE COUNT



Full season general admission costs between A$200 at Brisbane and A$460 at Sydney among the 15 clubs that list it. Reserved seat products start between A$175 and A$659 and reach A$1,375 at St Kilda. Carlton and Brisbane list no reserved seat or premium product on their public portals, so the chart shows only their general admission prices. These are publicly listed adult products, not each club's full membership offering.

Source: Club membership portals, captured October 9, 2026; mostly 2027 products. Adult prices only. Products for fewer than 8 games, interstate and Tasmanian products, streaming, supporter, junior, pet, and extra products are left out. Fremantle had not released its 2027 men's products. Sydney's top price is Blood 3, a membership that runs three years, priced per year. Neither Essendon nor GWS lists a standard full season general admission product, so the chart uses Essendon's Flexi Home & Away and GWS's 8 Game Sydney GA in its place.

Brisbane Lions adult membership, 2027

Three-peat premiers Brisbane offer a good view of what pricing looks like within a club whose demand runs ahead of its ground. The Gabba holds 39,202, Brisbane filled about 80% of it in 2026, and the club has 2.47 supporters for every seat offered.

Checked on the public portal on October 9, 2026. Figure 14 shows the A$200 general admission season product.

PRODUCT	SEASON	ADULT UPFRONT	ACCESS / SCOPE
General admission, three games	2027	A$93	Choice of three Gabba home matches; capacity limits and reserved seat upgrade terms apply.
Traditional Victorian	2027	A$187	GA entry to Lions matches at the MCG and Marvel, plus up to five Gabba home matches, subject to access terms.
General admission season	2027	A$200	GA entry to all Gabba home matches, subject to capacity and upgrade terms.
Kayo / support from home	2026 offer	From A$280	Streaming product advertised on the portal; sold separately from 2027 match access.

The club expects most 2027 Gabba home games to be fully ticketed, and GA members pay an extra fee for each match to upgrade to a reserved seat. The public portal lists no 2027 reserved seat or premium product, so those prices are not public. The portal says renewals for 2026 members open in late October.

Membership rights: Brisbane's published 2026 terms give voting rights to eligible adult members with a full season membership. A census needs separate fields for match access, finals priority and voting, and 2027 eligibility depends on the 2027 terms.

Membership product categories and club social growth appear in Appendix E.

11 State governments: Gather Round and Macquarie Point

Two state governments buy access to the AFL in different ways. South Australia pays to host Gather Round, a full round of matches in one state, and Tasmania is building Macquarie Point as a condition of a 19th club. Each deal raises the same question: who controls the revenue an event or a venue earns.

11.1 Gather Round

Gather Round puts all 9 matches of one round in a single state. South Australia has hosted it every year since 2023, and in 2026 it used Adelaide Oval, Norwood Oval, and Barossa Park. In June 2026 the AFL and the South Australian government signed a new 3 year agreement that keeps the event in the state until at least 2029. The fee the government pays is commercial in confidence.

CROWD	FROM INTERSTATE	ECONOMIC CONTRIBUTION	AGREEMENT
270,018	**37%**	**A$115M**	**2029**
Spectators at 9 matches, 9 to 12 April 2026	Estimated share of attendees from outside South Australia	2026, from an independent evaluation; more than A$400M since 2023	New 3 year term keeps the event in South Australia until at least 2029

The 2026 crowds show what a neutral round does to fill. Norwood Oval and Barossa Park each hosted 2 matches and filled 97% and 88% of capacity. On the published total, the 5 matches at Adelaide Oval averaged about 46,000, against 41,859 across all 27 of the ground's 2026 matches. The round averaged about 30,000 a match, below the league average of 37,546, because 4 of its 9 matches used small grounds.

The commercial terms are the open question. Most designated home clubs play their Gather Round match away from their own ground, and the public sources do not show how the AFL compensates them. They also do not show how the government fee, ticket revenue, and venue income divide between the AFL, the clubs, and the grounds. The A$115M figure measures spending in the state economy, so it does not measure revenue to the league or the clubs.

Source: South Australian Tourism Commission, Gather Round results and IER evaluation, 19 August 2026; AFL.com.au, Gather Round agreement, 11 June 2026; InDaily, 11 June 2026; afltables.com, 2026 crowds. The Adelaide Oval average is calculated from the published total less the Norwood Oval and Barossa Park crowds.

11.2 Why Macquarie Point

Macquarie Point is the 23,000 seat roofed stadium planned for Hobart's waterfront, a condition of Tasmania's entry to the AFL in 2028. AFL chief executive Andrew Dillon has held to a "no stadium, no team" position, and the funding agreement between the Tasmanian government and the AFL allows the deal to be terminated if the stadium is not built before the start of 2031.

That makes it the clearest link in this market between a venue decision and the shape of the league. A 19th club changes the fixture, opens a new home market for sponsors and broadcasters, and joins the AFL distribution model in Section 6. The Tasmania Devils passed 210,000 founding members in May 2025, with founding memberships on sale at A$10, before the club had played a game.

The 2026 crowds in Tasmania give a reference point. Hawthorn's four matches at UTAS Stadium in Launceston averaged 8,843, or 45% of capacity, and Richmond's match against Brisbane at Ninja Stadium in Hobart drew 10,200. Those matches involved Victorian home clubs, so they do not equate exactly to a Tasmanian team, but they do show the demand for AFL in Tasmania. The Devils will play their AFL home games at those two grounds from 2028 until Macquarie Point opens.

11.3 Where the project stands

BUDGET	FEDERAL FUNDING	STATE CAP	AFL CONTRIBUTION
A$1.13B	**A$240M**	**A$875M**	**A$15M**
23,000 seats under a translucent roof the AFL required	Pledged in 2023 and formally accepted in 2026	Up from the earlier A$375M cap	The three sources add up to the A$1.13B budget

MACQUARIE POINT TIMELINE

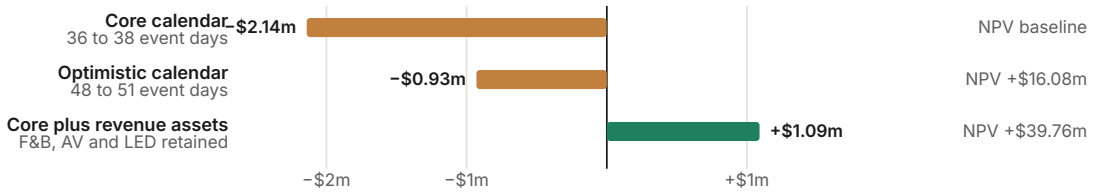
WHEN	STEP	WHAT HAPPENED OR IS PLANNED
Sept 2025	Planning Commission report	The Tasmanian Planning Commission recommended that the project not proceed, citing its scale on the site, its effect on Hobart's heritage and urban form, and a net social cost. The report assessed a A$945M stadium.
Dec 2025	Parliament approves	The Legislative Council approved the project 9 to 5 on 4 December, completing its passage through parliament.
Mar 2026	Opening moves to 2031	The Macquarie Point Development Corporation said construction would finish towards the end of 2030 and the venue would not host AFL matches before the 2031 season.
Apr 2026	Builders shortlisted	BESIX Watpac and the Constructure joint venture of Webuild, China Construction Oceania, and McConnell Dowell.
Jul to Sept 2026	Site works	Hazell Bros began archaeology and the removal of about 100,000 cubic meters of soil. Tests on a roof sample in September found it suitable for players, officials, and broadcast.
Oct to Dec 2026	Head contractor	A preferred builder was expected in October, with the contract signed at the end of 2026.
2027	Main construction	Work on the main structure is expected to begin in the middle of the year.
2028 to 2030	Devils enter the AFL	Home games at Ninja Stadium in Hobart and UTAS Stadium in Launceston.
2031	First season in Mac Point	The funding agreement allows termination if the stadium is not built before the start of 2031.

Source: Tasmanian Planning Commission final report, as reported by AFL.com.au, 17 September 2025; Pulse Tasmania, 4 December 2025; ABC News, 10 March, 19 April and 27 July 2026; AFL.com.au, stadium funding; Macquarie Point Development Corporation, monthly updates to September 2026. Status checked October 10, 2026.

The builder's price is the next fixed point. The three funding sources match the budget, so a contract above A$1.13B would need more money from one of them or a smaller scope. Once the contract is signed, the open commercial questions move to the operating agreement: who sells naming, pouring, and LED rights, and how that revenue splits between the venue owner, the Devils, and the AFL. Those terms are not public.

11.4 Who keeps the venue revenue

Figure 15. Macquarie Point, average operating result by scenario MODELED



In KPMG's scenarios, keeping the food and beverage, AV, and LED assets inside the project improves NPV by A$39.76M, against A$16.08M for the optimistic event calendar, so control of revenue moves the result more than extra event days do.

KPMG prepared these scenarios in 2024 dollars, before lifecycle costs and before the A$1.13B budget, so they show the direction of each lever and do not represent the current business case. Its central benefit cost ratio was 0.69.

Source: KPMG, Macquarie Point financial and cost benefit analysis, September 2024 and January 2025 supplement, A$2024, before lifecycle costs; Mac Point, project materials.

12 Commercial priorities

The public record shows where opportunities might exist. Turning these findings into revenue plans needs each club's sales, customer, and contract data.

PRIORITY	WHAT THE REPORT SUPPORTS	NEXT DECISION AND EVIDENCE
Matchday revenue	Revenue per attendee varies almost threefold across the five clubs that report it	Compare attendance growth with pricing, product mix and retained revenue, using accounts prepared the same way at each club.
Venue and fixture utilization	Most benchmark headroom sits at the MCG and Marvel	Rank fixtures by paid sales, member attendance, sellable capacity, opponent and timing.
Supporter conversion	Supporter surveys and membership tallies describe different markets	Use CRM records with duplicates removed, plus location and purchase history, to define reachable prospects.
Partnership development	Rights sit with several sellers, and six league agreements reach an end year by 2027	Confirm exclusivity, who controls the asset, renewal status and what the annual fee covers before valuing or pitching a deal.
Audience valuation	Published audience measures use different units and periods	Match verified reach, frequency, location and engagement to the asset and to what the buyer wants.

Recommendation: build revenue plans around what each club keeps and the audience it can reach. Public benchmarks set the questions, and the club, venue, broadcaster, or league that holds the data and the rights has to confirm the answers.

13 Signals worth tracking

SEVEN DATED SIGNALS WORTH TRACKING

SIGNAL	WHEN	WHAT IT WOULD TELL YOU
Crypto.com, OMO and the Asahi portfolio reach their end year	End 2026	The first test of category pricing since the broadcast deal
Toyota, Accor and CyberCX expire	End 2027	Whether premier tier pricing becomes observable
AFL 2026 financial result	Early 2027	Whether the A$164M revenue rise repeats in the second year of the broadcast deal
Gather Round 2027	April 2027	The venue list, crowds, and whether the host fee under the new agreement becomes public
Macquarie Point head contract	End 2026	Whether the A$1.13B budget holds once the builder's price is fixed, and who will control the venue's revenue assets
STRAUSS partnership begins	2027	Value of a net new deal in 2027
Tasmania club entry	2028	How a new club performs in a state that has hosted AFL matches but never had its own team

A Appendix A: Partner asset matrix

● Core to the partnership ○ Linked mention Blank: not visible in public evidence; the contract may still include it

PARTNER	TIER	COMP.	MATCH	MEDIA	EVENTS	VENUE	LIC.	COMM.	CUST.	SUPPLY	END
Toyota	Premier	●						●	○		End 2027
AAMI	Major	●	●					●	○		At least 2028
Carlton Draught	Major		○			●			○	●	Not stated
Coles	Major		○		●				○		Not stated
Continental Tyres	Major			●	●				○		Not stated
Crypto.com	Major			●					●		End 2026
McDonald's	Major		●		○			●	●		End 2031
NAB	Major	●						●			Not stated
Sportsbet	Major								●		Not stated
Telstra	Major			●	●			●	●	○	Not stated
Virgin Australia	Major		○		●	●			○	●	End 2030
Seven / Foxtel / Telstra	Media rights			●					●		2031
Fanatics	Strategic rights						●		●	●	2032
Asahi Beverages	Portfolio agreement		○			●			○	●	2026
Accor Hotels	Official					●			○	●	End 2027
Bunnings Warehouse	Official							●	●		Not stated
BWS	Official										Not stated
Chemist Warehouse	Official			●				●	○		Several years
Colgate	Official				●						Not stated
Cool Ridge	Official					●				●	End 2026
CyberCX	Official		●	○						●	End 2027
EnergyAustralia	Official					●		●		●	2030
Gatorade	Official		○			●				●	End 2026
Grant Burge	Official					●			○	●	End 2029
Hard Rated	Official										Not stated
Harvey Norman	Official										Not stated
Hostplus	Official										Not stated
Marsh	Official							●			Not stated
Monster Energy	Official				○				●		Not stated
OMO	Official		●							●	End 2026
Pepsi	Official					●				●	End 2026
Sharp EIT Solutions	Official										Not stated
Shell	Official										Not stated
Sherrin	Official		●				○			●	Not stated
Solo	Official					●				●	End 2026

PARTNER	TIER	COMP.	MATCH	MEDIA	EVENTS	VENUE	LIC.	COMM.	CUST.	SUPPLY	END
TCL	Official					●			○	●	End 2028
Visit Victoria	Official										Not stated
PUMA	Associate						○			●	Not stated

Asset classes: competition and naming, matchday and field, media and digital, events and awards, venue and hospitality, licensing and retail, community and pathways, customer and audience, supply and procurement. Media rights, the Fanatics license, and the Asahi portfolio appear as separate rows, so the matrix carries 38 rows against 35 directory brands. EnergyAustralia's 2030 end year assumes the five year term announced in 2026 starts that year. Gatorade, Cool Ridge, Pepsi and Solo sit inside the Asahi agreement and share its 2026 end year; Carlton Draught has a separate deal.

B Appendix B: Attendance by club, 2026

RANKED BY SHARE OF GROUND FILLED

CLUB	GAMES	SEATS OFFERED	ATTENDANCE	AVERAGE	FILL	SUPPORTERS PER SEAT
Adelaide	12	642,000	561,253	46,771	87.4%	1.18
Fremantle	11	661,716	568,847	51,713	86.0%	0.57
Sydney	12	524,643	431,882	35,990	82.3%	2.16
Brisbane	11	431,222	346,017	31,456	80.2%	2.47
Geelong	12	509,680	386,615	32,218	75.9%	1.03
West Coast	11	661,716	493,276	44,843	74.5%	0.97
Collingwood	12	1,060,402	768,143	64,012	72.4%	0.87
Carlton	11	820,178	583,622	53,057	71.2%	0.75
Port Adelaide	12	642,000	435,210	36,268	67.8%	0.39
Gold Coast	11	271,930	179,949	16,359	66.2%	0.56
North Melbourne	12	566,593	339,721	28,310	60.0%	0.34
Hawthorn	12	784,987	467,039	38,920	59.5%	0.57
St Kilda	11	633,454	368,549	33,504	58.2%	0.54
Western Bulldogs	11	586,773	335,818	30,529	57.2%	0.54
Essendon	12	873,678	499,014	41,584	57.1%	0.76
GWS	12	246,053	138,367	11,531	56.2%	0.65
Richmond	11	1,019,740	458,884	41,717	45.0%	0.44
Melbourne	11	960,723	410,893	37,354	42.8%	0.36
League	207	11,897,488	7,772,015	37,546	65.3%	0.79

The League row carries the AFL's official 2026 home and away attendance of 7,772,015. The 18 reconstructed club rows sum to 7,773,099, so the two differ by 1,084 across 207 matches.

C Appendix C: Attendance by venue, 2026

ALL 17 GROUNDS, RANKED BY MATCHES HOSTED. BIGGEST QUARTER: AVERAGE OF EACH MAIN GROUND'S BUSIEST QUARTER OF ITS 2026 HOME AND AWAY MATCHES

VENUE	CAPACITY	MATCHES	ATTENDANCE	AVERAGE	FILL	BIGGEST QUARTER
Marvel Stadium	53,343	46	1,441,777	31,343	58.8%	42,681
MCG	100,024	46	2,621,041	56,979	57.0%	82,584
Adelaide Oval	53,500	27	1,130,195	41,859	78.2%	50,367
Optus Stadium	60,156	23	1,104,532	48,023	79.8%	55,194
Gabba	39,202	11	346,017	31,456	80.2%	33,427
SCG	46,817	11	422,654	38,423	82.1%	42,267
GMHBA Stadium	40,000	10	294,015	29,402	73.5%	34,149
People First Stadium	27,500	9	157,303	17,478	63.6%	21,106
ENGIE Stadium	23,500	8	97,592	12,199	51.9%	18,149
UTAS Stadium	19,500	4	35,372	8,843	45.3%	
Manuka Oval	15,351	3	30,267	10,089	65.7%	
Norwood Oval	9,656	2	18,662	9,331	96.6%	
TIO Stadium	12,215	2	22,646	11,323	92.7%	
Barossa Park	12,000	2	21,121	10,560	88.0%	
Traeger Park	7,164	1	6,374	6,374	89.0%	
Hands Oval	14,350	1	13,331	13,331	92.9%	
Ninja Stadium	19,500	1	10,200	10,200	52.3%	

D Appendix D: Method and data notes

D.1 Season reconstruction

The AFL's official attendance is 7,772,015. The reconstructed home club rows total 7,773,099, which is 1,084 more (about 0.014%). Venue rows use the same reconstruction, and club splits carry that margin. Finals sit outside the attendance analysis and appear only as context in Section 9.

D.2 Capacity, fill and modeled attendance headroom

Fill is recorded attendance divided by nominal capacity for home matches, which can differ from the tickets a venue can sell. For each of the nine main grounds, headroom is its 2026 matches multiplied by its busiest quarter average, less recorded attendance, with a floor of zero, and the total adds the nine results. The busiest quarter is the ground's top 25% of 2026 home and away crowds, rounded to the nearest whole match (half up), using the full season at every ground. The inputs in Appendix C give 2,285,705 attendances, 74.3% of them at the MCG and Marvel. It is an annual scenario in which busier matches offset quieter ones, and it measures neither verified unsold tickets nor achievable demand.

D.3 Match revenue per attendee

Five clubs disclose match revenue lines with different scopes. Each ratio is the club's 2025 reported line divided by its 2025 home attendance, which differs from an average paid ticket price or a standard net yield. Membership revenue sits outside the line, while member attendance can sit inside the attendance count. The A$1 and 10% scenarios hold every other input constant and leave out extra costs.

D.4 Supporters and members

Roy Morgan Single Source, July 2025 to June 2026, n=59,959, compared with the AFL's standardized 2025 membership tallies. Neither the survey estimate nor the membership count is a matched customer record with duplicates removed. Supporters divided by home capacity across the season is an indicative ratio, and neither that ratio nor the gap between supporters and members measures ticket demand or the number of prospects without a membership.

D.5 Partner census

Directory snapshot: 22 September 2026. The directory lists 35 brands; the asset matrix has 38 rows because it adds media rights, the Fanatics license, and the Asahi portfolio. End year counts treat the Asahi portfolio as one agreement. STRAUSS starts in 2027 and sits outside the current count. Core and linked marks follow visible evidence only. The census keeps apart values disclosed by a party to the deal, press reports, estimates, earlier contracts, and goods in kind or program funding.

D.6 Membership census

The membership census lists 361 products from the 18 official club portals on October 9, 2026, with junior, pet, and extra products included and AFLW products left out. Each product sits in one family by its main access. Premium means a lounge, function room, or hospitality; flexible means two to nine games or a ticket bundle; extras include Grand Final guarantees, donations, sponsorships, and VFL or SANFL products. Figure 14 compares adult prices for full season general admission, reserved seat or bay, and premium or social club products, and leaves out products for fewer than 8 games and interstate or Tasmanian products. Essendon's Flexi Home & Away and GWS's 8 Game Sydney GA stand in for full season general admission. Broadcaster counts are listed relationships, so a brand buying from two broadcasters counts twice.

D.7 Dates of the data

Report last updated: October 11, 2026. Main crowd analysis: 2026. Club finances and match revenue ratios: 2025. Supporter survey: July 2025 to June 2026; membership tally: 2025. Membership products: October 9, 2026, mostly 2027 products. League partner and club social snapshots: September 2026. Macquarie Point status: October 10, 2026. Gather Round results: August 2026. A news search on October 9, 2026 found no announced renewal for Crypto.com, OMO, or the Asahi agreement. The international matchday benchmark and the food prices use earlier years, labeled on each. Money is in Australian dollars except the US$ international chart.

D.8 Unreconciled figures

Club reports show A$468M of distributions against A$461.5M in the AFL's club support measure. The club rows total A$1.436B of revenue against A$1.442B in the published summary. The A$2.178B industry total comes from SportsIndustryAU on its own basis. Each pair appears as published, with its basis labeled.

E Appendix E: Supporting market detail

Supporting detail with different reporting periods and census scopes. Each item answers a specific question, and the values do not compare directly with each other.

Figure E.1. Pie price published by each venue REPORTED



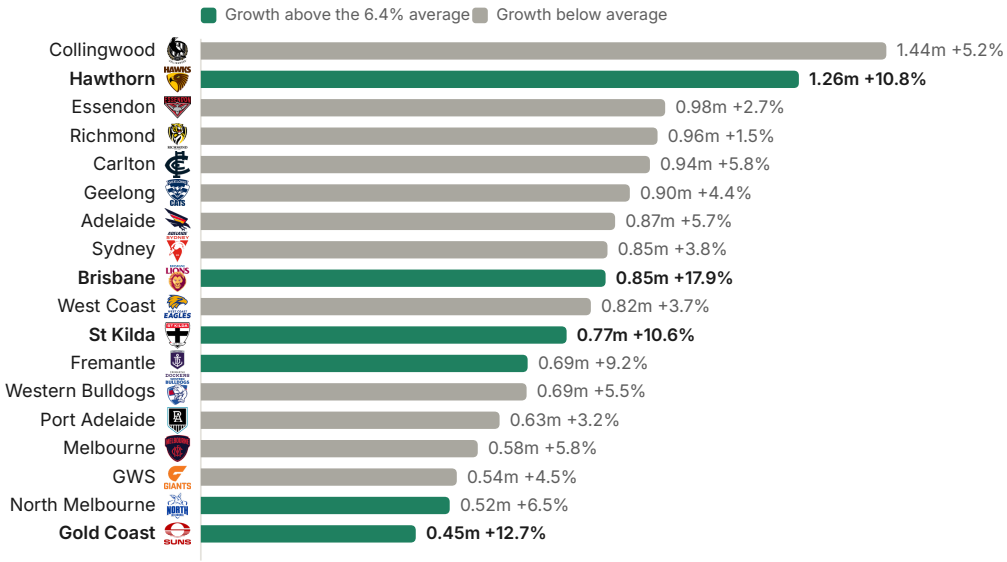
Venue food prices give context on affordability. The three examples differ in year and item, and they show neither average spend per fan nor the share a club keeps.

Source: Marvel Stadium, 2026 food prices (AFL.com.au, price freeze announcement); Adelaide Oval, 2025 kiosk menu release; Melbourne Cricket Ground 2024 prices as reported by Zero Hanger, March 2024.

FOOD AND DRINK PRICES PUBLISHED BY THE VENUES

VENUE	YEAR	PIE	HOT CHIPS	HOT DOG	WATER	BEER
Marvel Stadium	2026	$4.70	$4.90	$6.00	$4.90	Not published
Adelaide Oval	2025	$5.00	Not published	Not published	Not published	$10.90 West End pint
MCG	2024	$6.20	$6.20	$6.00	$4.70	$11.50 schooner; $13.50 Carlton Draught pint

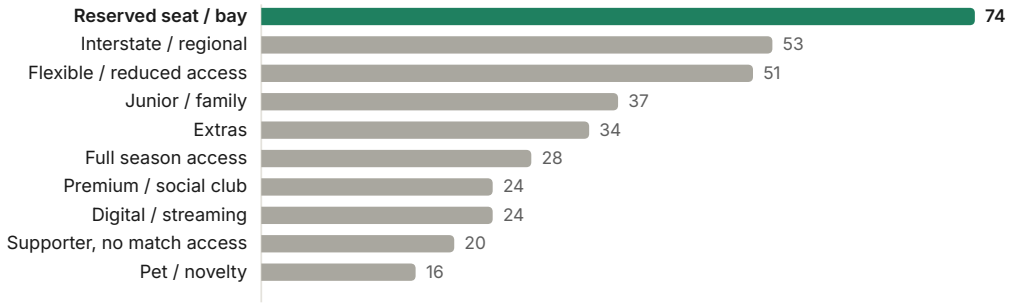
Figure E.2. Club social following and annual growth ESTIMATE



Collingwood has the largest following at 1.44 million, and Brisbane grew fastest at 17.9%. The counts add platforms together without removing duplicates, and growth alone does not show engagement, local reach or sales.

Source: SportsIndustryAU (footyindustry.com), club social media charts, 2025 and 2026. Facebook, Instagram, X, and TikTok, with duplicates left in.

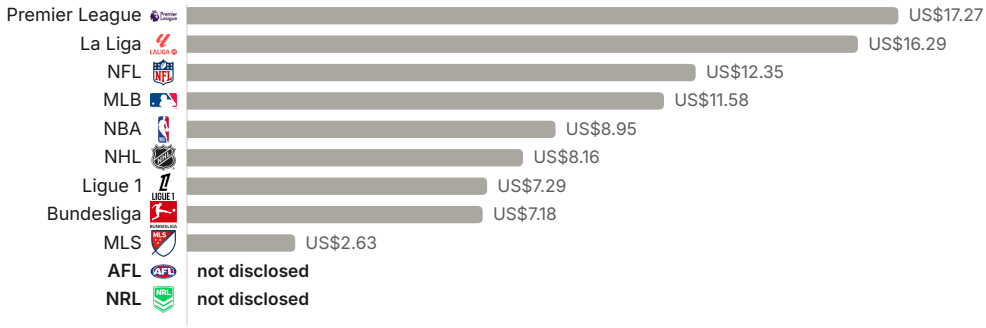
Figure E.3. Membership products by family PUBLIC PAGE COUNT



The October census found 361 products across the 18 clubs, leaving out AFLW products. Reserved seat and bay products are the largest family, at 74, followed by interstate and regional products, at 53. Brisbane's 2026 terms give eligible full season members a vote, and no product name says so, so voting needs its own field.

Source: Club membership portals for all 18 clubs, 361 products captured October 9, 2026, excluding AFLW. Appendix D.6 defines the families.

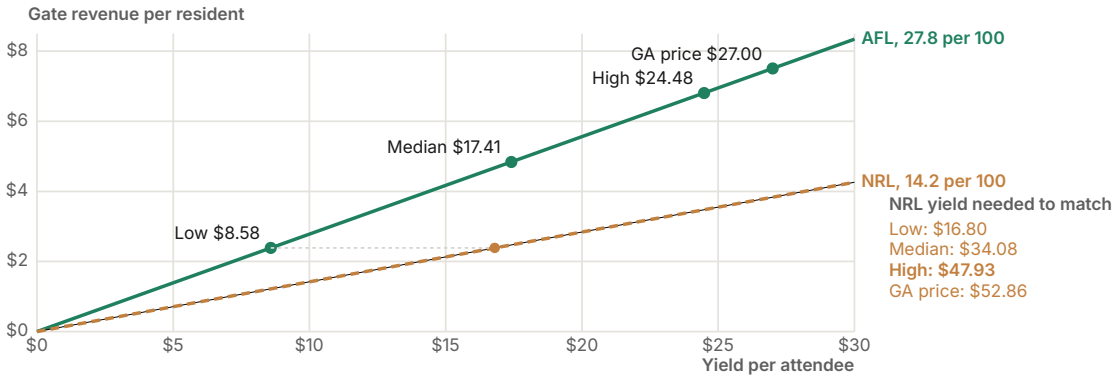
Figure E.4. Matchday revenue per resident, 2024 DIFFERENT SCOPE



The source leaves out both Australian codes because neither discloses matchday revenue. Placing the AFL or NRL here would need assumptions about what their revenue includes, so the chart stays as international context.

Source: Sports Value, league matchday revenues 2024; published league attendance records; national population estimates. Tickets, memberships, parking and concessions.

Figure E.5. Gate revenue per resident against yield per attendee, AFL and NRL MODELED



This model shows attendance arithmetic only. At the reported attendance rates, the NRL would need about A$47.93 per attendee to match the revenue per resident the AFL would earn at A$24.48. The model uses five AFL clubs' 2025 ratios. Neither league discloses its gate revenue, and the NRL publishes no yields.

Source: Club 2025 annual reports; AFL.com.au, 2025 general admission price; league attendance records; Playbook Strategies model.

F Appendix F: Sources

- afltables.com, 2026 crowds and season results
- South Australian Tourism Commission, Gather Round 2026 results (August 2026)
- AFL.com.au, Gather Round agreement to 2029 (June 2026)
- InDaily, Gather Round agreement (June 2026)
- AFL corporate partners directory (September 2026)
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- Macquarie Point strategic business case
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- Marketing Mag, Toyota AFL renewal (2019)
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- Adelaide Oval, 2025 kiosk prices
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- Asahi Beverages, AFL partnership (December 2022)
- Brisbane Lions official membership portal: 2027 adult prices for GA season, three game GA and Traditional Victorian; 2026 Kayo offer (checked October 9, 2026)
- Brisbane Lions 2026 membership terms: access, finals priority and voting eligibility

Last updated: October 11, 2026. Each dataset has its own collection date, listed in Appendix D.7. Playbook Strategies drew the figures from sources believed reliable on those dates and has not audited them. Accounting scope, survey definitions and disclosure differ by source. The scenarios are illustrations, and every input needs checking before a commercial decision. This document is for information and is not financial advice. Playbook Strategies is independent of the AFL and its clubs, and no league or club reviewed or endorsed this briefing.

About the author



Katherine Rowe is the founder of Playbook Strategies, an independent sports business consultancy. She works with rights holders on revenue strategy, partnership valuation, data activation, and fan intelligence, and consults for the ATX Open and other international sports properties.

Before Playbook Strategies, she was Vice President of Client Strategy and Insights at CrowdIQ/Fancam, and she worked at Salesforce and Kraft Analytics Group. She began her career as a U.S. Army Signal officer.

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